THE PIANO BUTLER · LEVEL BOOK

Beginner

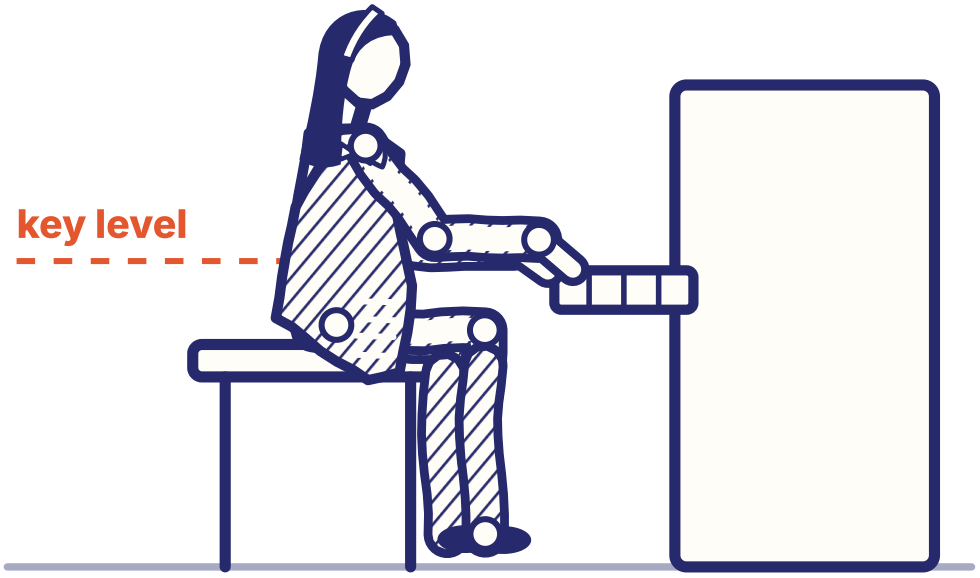
Read it like a storybook: one step on each page, a big picture, a few words, and one thing to try at the piano. After each room, a page to practise.

THE ROOMS

1 · Sitting and hands
2 · The keyboard
3 · Finger numbers
4 · The staff and the clefs
5 · The beat
6 · Notes: crotchet and minim
7 · Notes: three beats and four
8 · Loud and soft
9 · Ear training

Sitting and hands

SCAN TO LISTEN

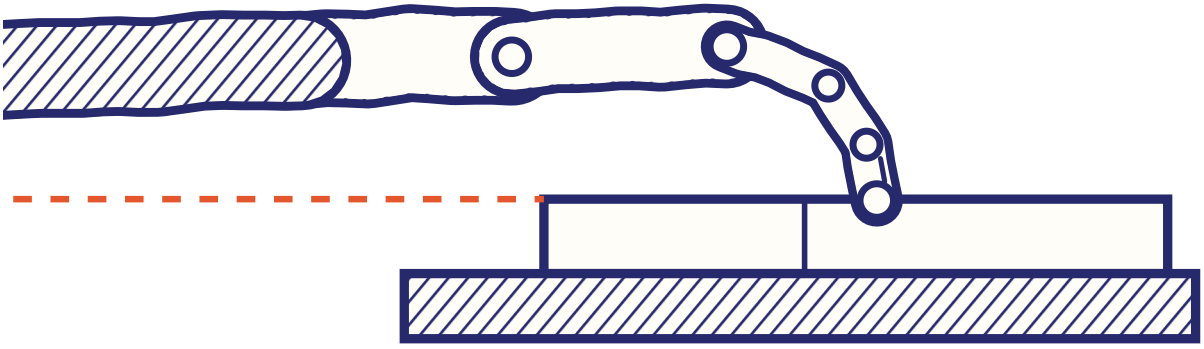


Sit tall on the front half of the stool, with both **feet flat** on the floor.

Your arms float out in front, **level with the keys**, like a table top.

AT THE PIANO

Sit down. Lift your shoulders up to your ears, then let them drop.

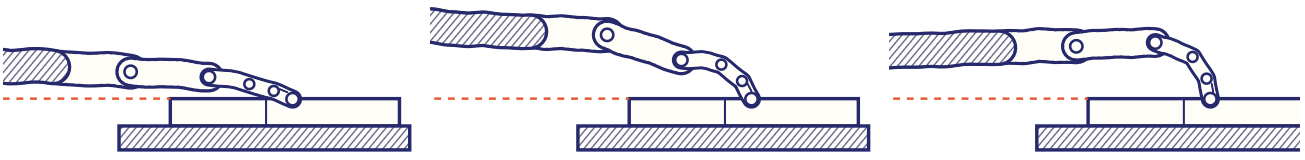


Hold a small ball in your hand. That **round shape** is your playing hand.

Your knuckles stand up like a **bridge**, and you play on your **fingertips**.

AT THE PIANO

Hold a ball or an orange. Put your hand on the keys without changing its shape.



× flat × fallen in ✓ round

A **flat** hand is fast asleep. A bridge that has **fallen in** cannot carry anything.

The **round** hand can play all day.

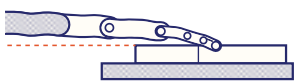
AT THE PIANO

Make the flat hand, then the fallen bridge, then the round hand. Feel the difference.

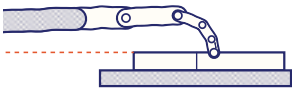
1 Flat, fallen in, or round?

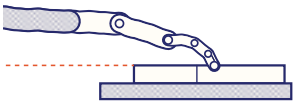
★☆☆

Write the word under each hand. The first is done.



flat





2 Too low, too high, or right?

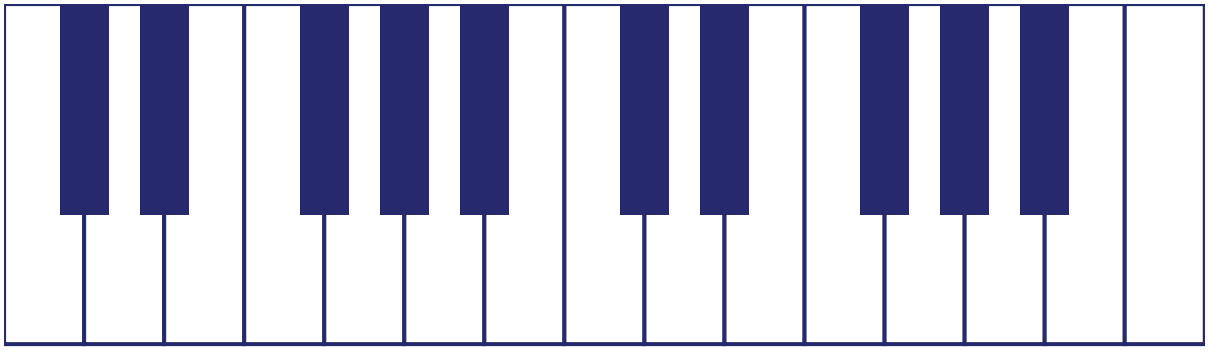
★★☆

Write too low, too high or right.

WHAT YOU SEE	THE STOOL IS
The elbows are well below the keys; the forearms go uphill.	too low
The forearms are level with the keys.	_____
The elbows are above the keys; the wrists drop down to them.	_____

The keyboard

SCAN TO LISTEN

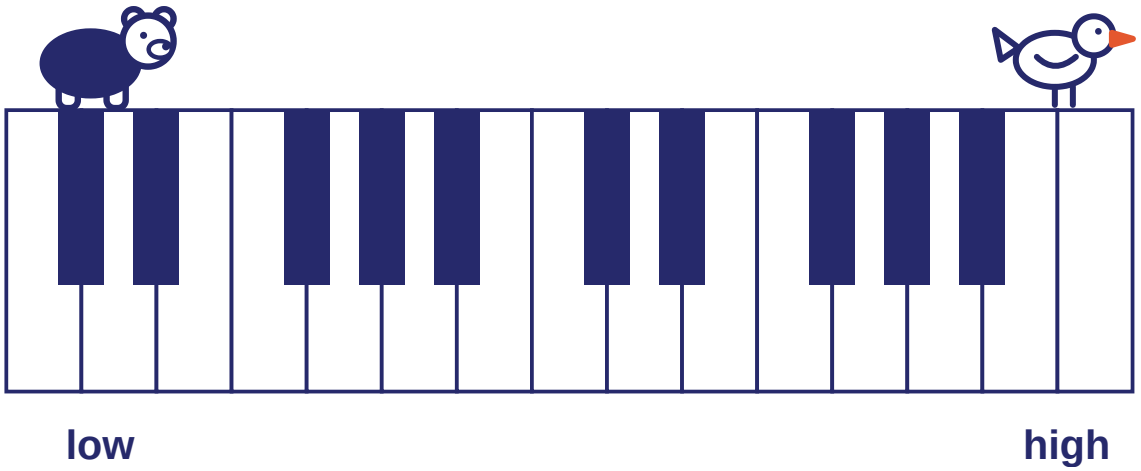


Look at the black keys. They come in **twos** and **threes**, again and again, all the way along.

Find the pattern once and you can never get lost.

AT THE PIANO

Touch every group of two black keys, from the left end to the right end. Then every group of three.



Left is low, like a big grumpy bear. **Right is high**, like a little bird.

Go to the right and every key sounds a little higher.

AT THE PIANO

Play the lowest key you can reach, then the highest. Bear, then bird.



Every white key has a letter. Beside the **two** black keys live **C, D, E**. Beside the **three** live **F, G, A, B**.

After B comes C again: seven letters, round and round.

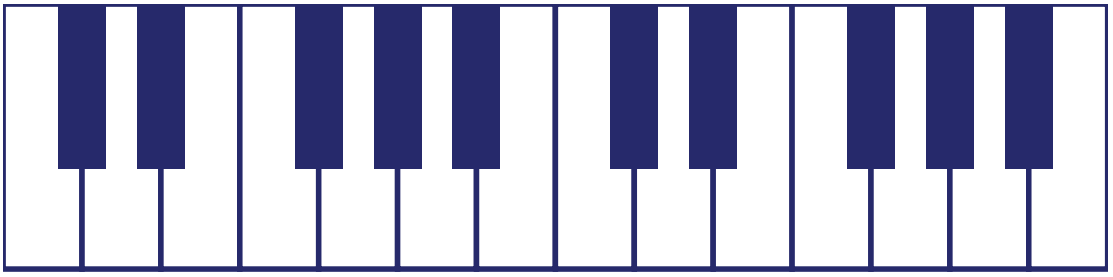
AT THE PIANO

Find a group of two black keys. Play the three white keys around it and say C, D, E.

1 Twos and threes

★☆☆

Circle every group of two black keys. Draw a box round every group of three. How many of each?

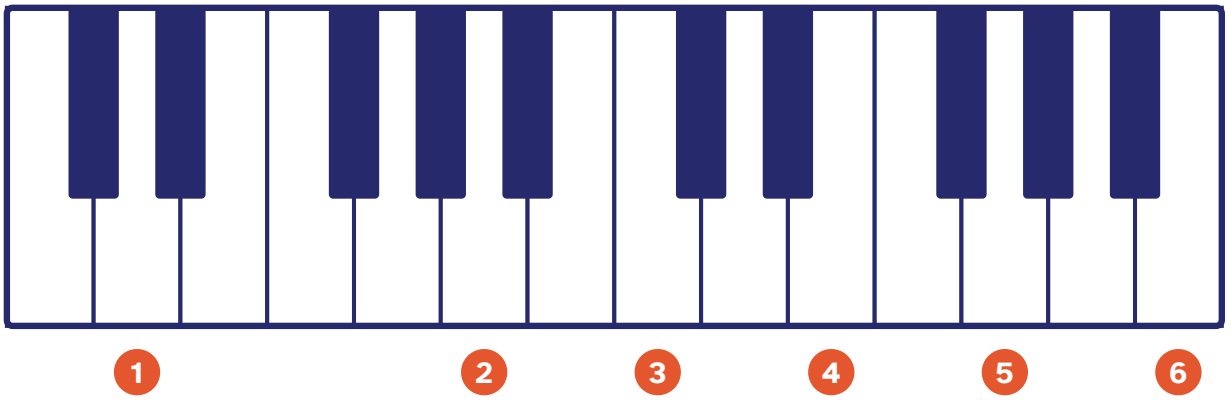


groups of two ☐ groups of three ☐

2 Name the keys

★☆☆

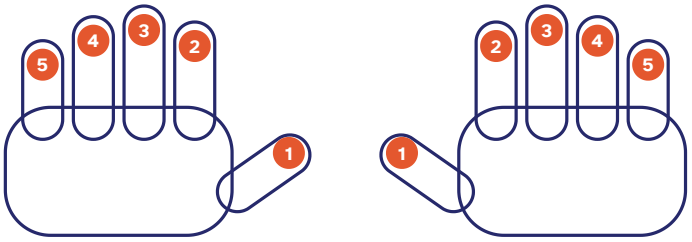
Find the black-key group next to each number. Write the letter of the numbered key. The first is done.



1 D 2 ☐ 3 ☐ 4 ☐ 5 ☐ 6 ☐

Finger numbers

SCAN TO LISTEN



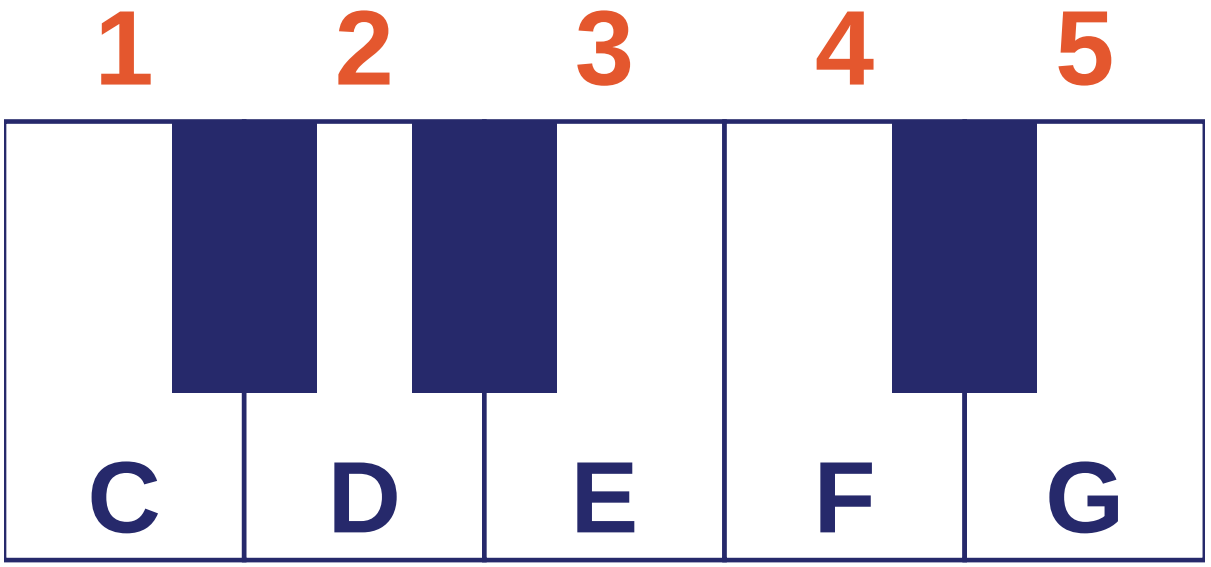
left hand *right hand*

Every finger has a **number**. The **thumb is 1**, then 2, 3, 4, and the little finger is **5**.

It is the same in both hands: thumbs are always 1.

AT THE PIANO

Hold up both hands. Wiggle finger 1, then 2, 3, 4, 5, saying the numbers.



Find any **C**: the white key just left of two black keys. Put your right thumb on it. Now **C D E F G** are fingers **1 2 3 4 5**.

In the left hand the little finger starts: C D E F G are **5 4 3 2 1**.

AT THE PIANO

Right thumb on C. Play C D E F G and back, saying the finger numbers. Then the left hand, starting with finger 5.

1 Finger numbers

★☆☆

Write the number of each finger. They are the same in both hands. The first is done.

FINGER	NUMBER	FINGER	NUMBER
thumb	1	ring finger	
index finger		little finger	
middle finger			

2 Which finger?

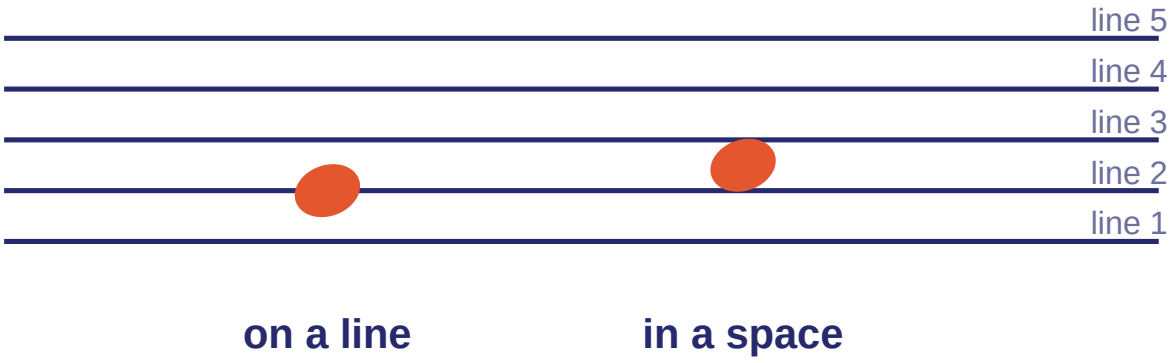
★☆☆

Right hand, thumb on C. Write the finger that plays each note. The first is done.

NOTE	E	G	D	F	C
Finger	3				

The staff and the clefs

SCAN TO LISTEN



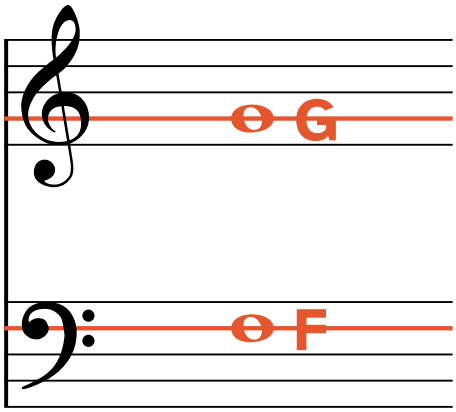
on a line **in a space**

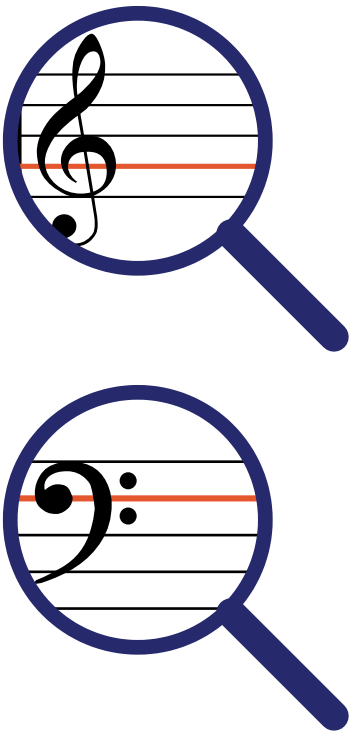
Music is written on **five lines**, called the **staff**.

A note can sit **on a line**. Or it can sit **in a space**. Higher up means higher on the piano.

AT THE PIANO

Count the lines from the bottom: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5. Then count the four spaces.





Treble clef = G clef
curls round line 2: G

Bass clef = F clef
its dots hug line 4: F

A **clef** at the start says which notes the lines stand for.

The **treble clef** is the Queen of the high notes: her curl wraps round the line for **G**. The **bass clef** is the King of the low notes: his two dots hug the line for **F**.

AT THE PIANO

Play any high key with your right hand: the Queen's side. Then any low key with your left: the King's side.

1 The clefs

★☆☆

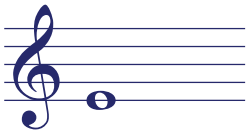
Write the name of each clef and the note it marks.

CLEF	NAME	IT MARKS THE LINE FOR
		
		

2 Line or space?

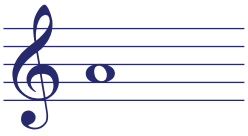
★☆☆

Circle line or space, then write its number (counted from the bottom). The first is done.

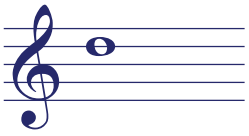


line · space

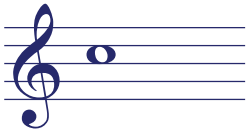
1



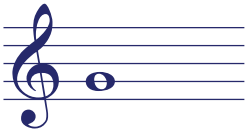
line · space



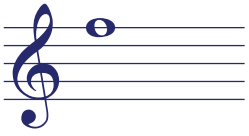
line · space



line · space



line · space



line · space

The beat

SCAN TO LISTEN



Music has a steady **beat**, like a heartbeat. It never speeds up and never stops.

We count the beats: 1, 2, 3, 4, and round again.

AT THE PIANO

Put a hand on your heart. Tap that steady beat on your knee and count 1 2 3 4.



Bar lines put the beats into groups called **bars**. **Beat 1** of every bar is the strongest.

Sometimes a beat is **silent**. You still count it.

AT THE PIANO

Clap three in a bar: STRONG, weak, weak. Then leave out one clap, but keep counting.

1 How many beats in each bar?

★☆☆

Count the dots between the bar lines. The first is done.



3







2 Add the bar lines

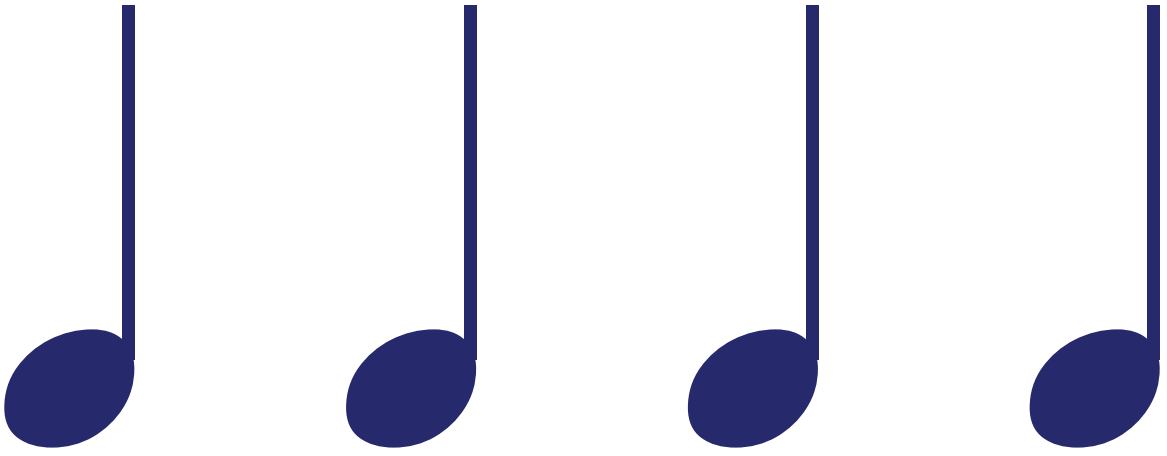
★★☆

Beat 1 is the big coral dot. Draw a bar line just before each one (the first is done).



Notes: crotchet and minim

SCAN TO LISTEN



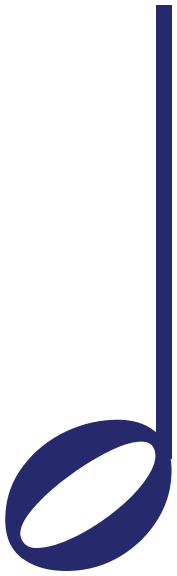
1 2 3 4

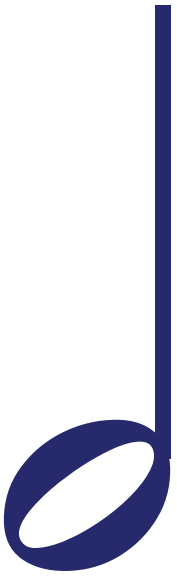
This is a **crotchet**. It lasts **one beat**.

Four crotchets fill a bar of four: play, play, play, play.

AT THE PIANO

Play C four times, one for each beat, counting 1 2 3 4.





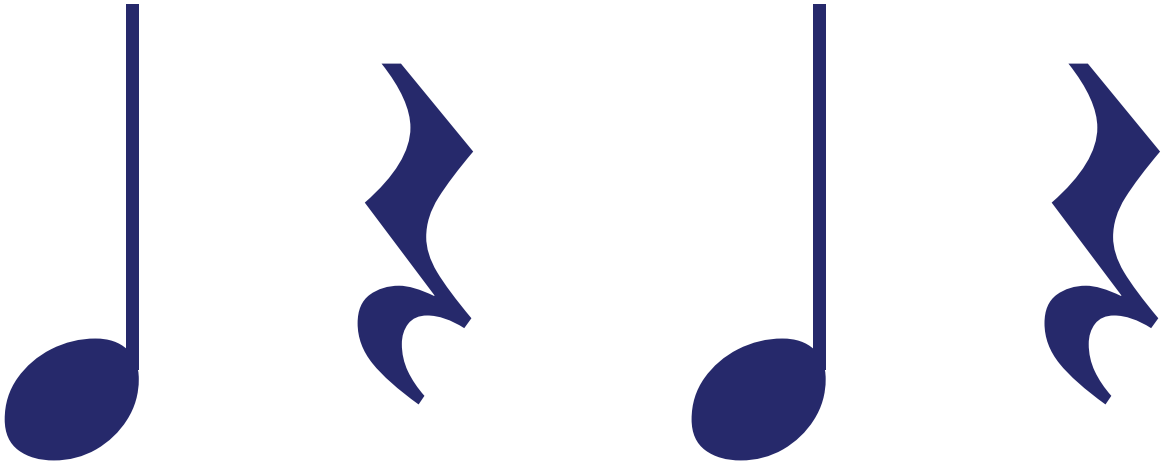
1 – 2 3 – 4

This is a **minim**. Its head is empty, and it lasts **two beats**.

Play on the first beat and **hold** through the second.

AT THE PIANO

Play C as a minim: press on 1, hold through 2. Then again on 3, holding through 4.



play **shh** **play** **shh**

Silence has signs too, called **rests**. A **crotchet rest** is one beat of silence.

You count a rest just like a note. You just do not play.

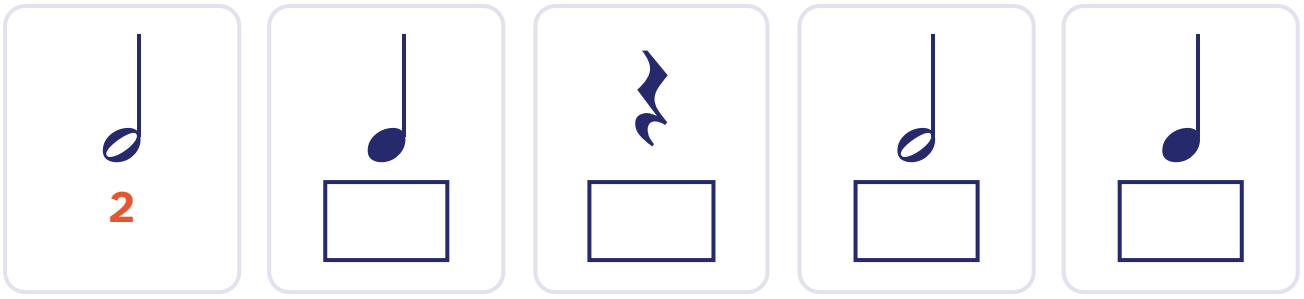
AT THE PIANO

Play, shh, play, shh: C on beats 1 and 3, silence on 2 and 4. Keep counting.

1 One beat or two?

★☆☆

Write 1 or 2 under each. The first is done.



2 Fill the bar

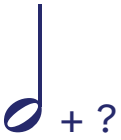
★★☆

Four beats in each bar. Write the missing note: crotchet or minim. The first is done.



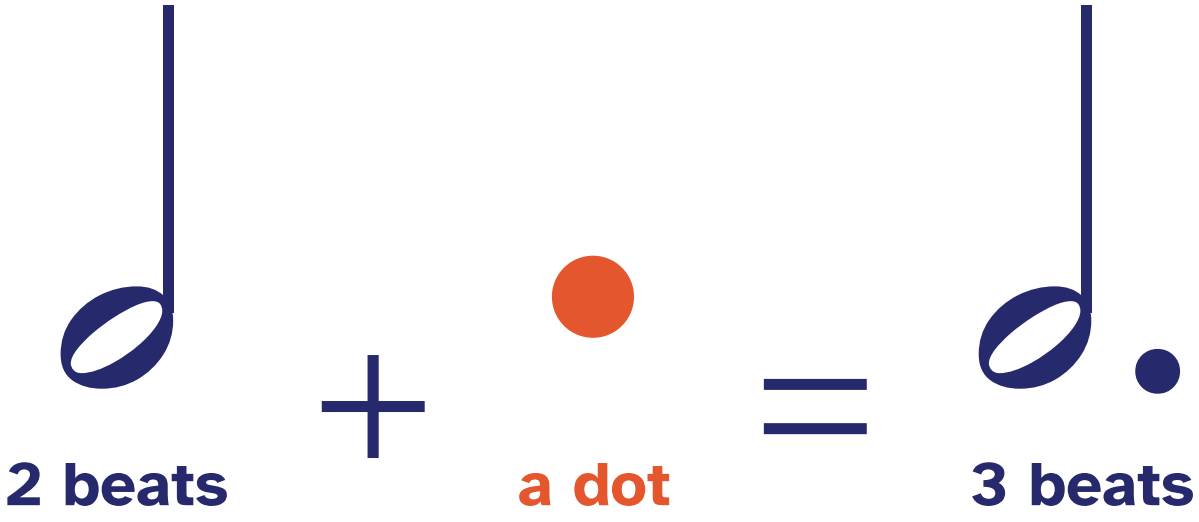
minim





Notes: three beats and four

SCAN TO LISTEN

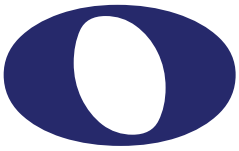


A **dot** after a minim adds one more beat.

Two beats and one more: a **dotted minim** lasts **three beats**.

AT THE PIANO

Play C and hold for 1 2 3. Lean in on beat 1.



1 – 2 – 3 – 4

This is a **semibreve**: an empty head and no stem. It lasts **four beats**, a whole bar of four.

Press once, and listen until the sound has had all four beats.

AT THE PIANO

Play C and hold for 1 2 3 4. Lift exactly when the next bar begins.

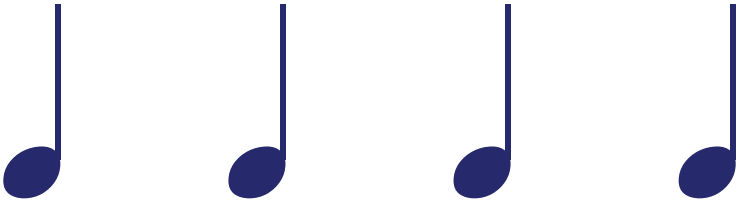
1 semibreve



2 minims



4 crotchets



Now you know the family. Each note is **half** of the one above it.

One semibreve is as long as two minims, or four crotchets.

AT THE PIANO

Play four crotchets on C. Then one semibreve, held for all four beats. The same length!

1 Name and beats ★☆☆

Fill in the table. The first row is done.

NOTE	NAME	BEATS
	semibreve	4
	_____	☐
	_____	☐
	_____	☐

2 Three in a bar ★★☆

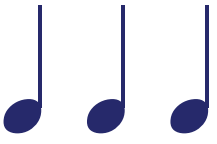
Each bar has three beats. Count 1 2 3 and play each bar. Write how many notes it has. The first is done.



1



☐



☐

Loud and soft

SCAN TO LISTEN



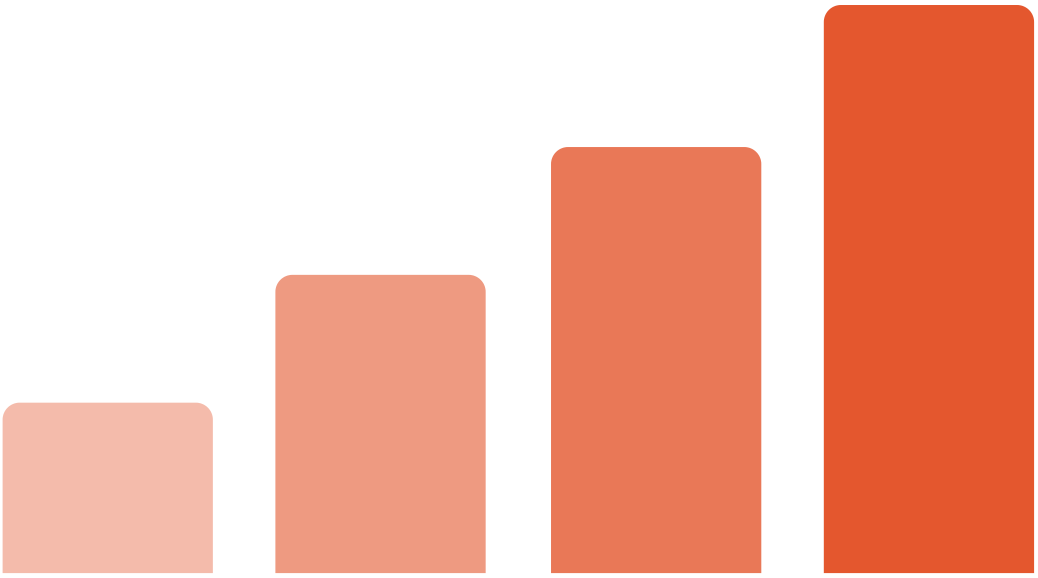
p soft ***f*** loud

Music can be **soft** or **loud**. The signs are Italian: ***p*** for *piano*, soft, and ***f*** for *forte*, loud.

To play louder, let your arm feel heavy. Do not hit the key.

AT THE PIANO

Play C softly, like a secret. Then play it loudly, like calling across a field.



p	*mp*	*mf*	*f*
soft	quite soft	quite loud	loud

In between come two more. The ***m*** is for *mezzo*, which means **half** or **medium**: ***mp*** is quite soft, ***mf*** is quite loud.

Soft does not mean slow, and loud does not mean fast. The beat stays the same.

AT THE PIANO

Play C four times: p, mp, mf, f. Four steps, the same speed.

1 What does it mean?

★☆☆

Write soft, loud, quite soft or quite loud. The first is done.

SIGN	MEANS
p	soft
f	
mp	
mf	

2 Play it

★☆☆

Play C four times: p, mp, mf, f. Four steps, the same speed. Tick a circle each day.

Room 9 ◆ 1 of 1

Ear training

SCAN TO PLAY

1
Low, middle or high?

2
Same clapping, or different?

3
Same tune, or different?

4
Which way did it go?

5
Find the note

Listen first, then play. Good ears make good fingers.

Five listening games are waiting in the app. Scan the code and play one each day.

AT THE PIANO

Before you play a note, sing it. Then play it and listen: were you right?

1 Floor, tummy or sky?

★☆☆

A grown-up plays one key: very low, in the middle, or very high. Eyes closed! Point to the floor, your tummy or the sky.

2 Copy-cat clap

★☆☆

A grown-up claps a short pattern. Clap it back exactly. Then swap: you clap, they copy.